AVA BIRDWELL

avabirdwell@gmail.com | +1 (703) 635-0401 | Current: Rockland, Maine

Education

MS, University of Virginia (UVA), Charlottesville, VA August 2025
Commerce, Biotechnology Concentration
BA, University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA May 2024
Environmental Science, Minor in Public Policy and Leadership
International coursework: **Bond University**, Australia (Spring 2023); **Oxford University**, England (Summer 2022)

Work Experience

Environmental Steward & Educator, **AmeriCorps,** Hurricane Island, Maine April 2026 – Present

- Design and deliver place-based and research-driven marine science education programs on a remote island while participating as an active member of Hurricane Island's community.
- Tailor lessons to diverse student groups across a range of ages, backgrounds, and learning levels.
- Support aquaculture and fisheries research on scallops and lobsters. Assist with island operations and maintenance.
- Coordinate volunteer engagement activities, including recruitment, event facilitation, and implementation of Maine Conservation Corps and AmeriCorps volunteer-management practices. Represent organizational missions in public-facing contexts.

Laboratory Technician & Manager, **Environmental Science Department**, UVA July 2024 – April 2026

- Supported coastal ecosystem research by processing 500+ environmental samples to assess carbon, nitrogen, and water quality metrics.
- Compiled data for Virginia's Eastern Shore Long Term Ecological Research site while advancing skills with analytical lab instruments.
- Trained and managed new lab members in data collection and handling procedures.
- Managed DNA extractions for deciduous trees on the East coast, and optimized extraction procedures.

Research Assistant, **Sloane Lab**, UVA October 2024 – April 2026

- Lead research assistant for the project: *Broadening Access to Climate AI Innovation*
- Managed review of interdisciplinary literature, coordinated team meetings, and tracked project deliverables.
- Conducted outreach to 80+ experts and community members for a stakeholder-driven workshop with 25+ participants.
- Led analysis of workshop presentations and discussions, synthesizing insights with support from AI tools.
- Co-authored future-facing report aimed at shaping future climate science and AI research questions.

Development Intern, **Community Climate Collaborative**, Charlottesville, VA June 2023 – August 2023

- Contributed to Five Year Annual report to transparently convey non-profit environmental impact to community members, donors, and stakeholders. Coordinated distribution of over 200 physical and online copies.
- Assisted development of fundraising initiatives and revised grant submissions.

Involvement

Salsa Instructor, **UVA Salsa Club,** UVA February 2024 – May 2025

- Led and coordinated Latin dance lessons and workshops for 2-40+ participants across elementary schools, community events, and university settings.
- Conducted weekly instructor training and promoted the cultural history of Latin dance styles.

Member, **Zero Waste Ambassador,** UVA Office of Sustainability September 2024 – May 2025

- Diverted over 3 tons of waste from local landfills by ensuring clean compost streams for Blackbear industrial facility with the team.
- Created educational materials and led outreach efforts at UVA events to promote sustainable waste practices.

***Server,* Bizou Restaurant,** Charlottesville, VA September 2022 – September 2024

- Served up to 25 people at one time for an award-winning, high-volume restaurant.
- Utilized interpersonal, communication and teamwork skills in a busy, customer-service environment to provide an exceptional experience for patrons.
- Demonstrated excellent time management skills working part-time while a full-time student.

***Researcher,* Maldives Whale Shark Research Programme,** South Ari Atoll Spring 2022

- Collected data on marine megafauna and environmental variables while living aboard a research vessel on the Indian Ocean with 8 international colleagues.
- Identified and logged individual whale sharks using photo-identification.

Publications & Presentations

Birdwell, A. (2026). Broadening Access to Climate AI Innovation. Environmental Futures Forum. University of Virginia, Virginia.

Birdwell, A., Mamalakis, A., Sloane, M., & Nyelele, C. (2025). Broadening Access to Climate AI Innovation. University of Virginia, 2025-09-29. **https://doi.org/10.18130/npqy-pk55**

Skills and Interests

Language: Spanish (intermediate written and oral)
Software: Microsoft Office (Excel, Word, PowerPoint); Excel Udemy Certificate, MATLAB, STATA, SPSS, Tableau
Interests: Scuba Diving, Volleyball (UVA Women's Club Volleyball team 2021 – 2024), Ashtanga Yoga, Reading fiction, Journaling, Stand-up comedy

Certifications

Wilderness First Responder, Wilderness Medical Associates International, 2026
PADI Open Water Certification, 2023
NASBLA Virginia Boating License, 2017

Scholarships and Awards

Major (USMC) Calvin C. Crum Global Scholarship for study in South America, 2025, $1000
University of Virginia McIntire Academic Scholarship, 2024, $5000
University of Virginia Dean's List, 2024